Week 1: What is International Law

LAWS2000/8015 International Law

What is international law?

A. Try to define international law in a single sentence.

Discuss some of the essential elements in this definition and the basic features of international law. Be prepared to give examples and elaborate with reference to real world events.

B. *"Almost all nations observe almost all principles of international law and almost all of their obligations almost all of the time"* Louis Henkin

What do you think of this statement? If states do generally obey international law, why do they obey it, and why do they sometimes disobey it?

Be prepared to debate and give reasons BOTH in favour and against this proposition. Refer to traditional theories and modern realities.

C. In June 2025, *The Guardian* published the article "Are we Witnessing the Death of International Law?" What is your answer to this question?

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